

order to progress, failing which will send you right back to the start of the puzzle for another round and executing the same move. It's an addictive and unforgiving cycle.

IKARUGA

Ikaruga is a fantastic arcade shooter. There are few games that truly define the bullet hell genre, and Ikaruga is one of them. In addition to being an extremely polished and well-made game, it's also devilishly difficult, all because of the flawless implementation of one simple mechanic. Colour switching. Enemy projectiles in the game are either black or white. Your ship's polarity can be switched between black and white, with black being able to absorb black projectiles and vice versa. The same mechanic



works when dealing damage to enemies as well. Just the addition of one other thing to keep your mind on when the screen is swarming with bullets ups the challenge to a whole new level.

DEVIL MAY CRY 3: DANTE'S AWAKENING

The Devil May Cry franchise has always been known for being challenging from the get go, however when Devil May Cry 3: Dante's Awakening dropped, it was almost impossible to complete without cheating or being a literal gamer god. It was so difficult, in fact, that the game had to be re-released with the difficulty toned down. Enemies took forever to die, and you had to be perfect in your combat execution; even a small misstep would mean a do-over.



NINJA GAIDEN

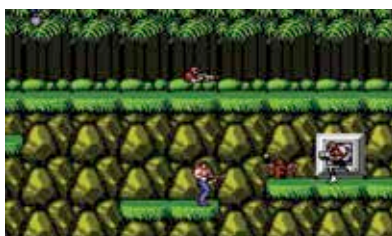
Ninja Gaiden is one of those games that's infamous for being difficult twice over. Let us explain. The game was first released as an 8-bit, 2D side-scroller for the NES in 1988. It was painfully difficult then, with all the checkmarks to make the game as much of a pain for players as possible. Difficult platforming sections, wave after wave of ene-



mies, complex and difficult boss fights. You'd think that would make anyone hate the game, but it was so good you kept playing anyway (and hating ourselves for it), because we're all masochists that way. But if that wasn't enough, Ninja Gaiden was remade and re-released in 2004 for the PS2 and Xbox, this time with a spankin' new 3D makeover, and a whole new world of pain. Enemies in the game were incredibly fast, and the bosses (if you were ever reached them) required superhuman reflexes. This version of Ninja Gaiden was re-released with an easier 'Ninja Dog' mode so that people could actually make it past level 1.

CONTRA

This is a game that needs no introduction; everyone knows the Konami code by heart at this point, even if they don't remember the game it was used in. Contra is a 2D side scroller with some platforming elements, plenty of power pickups and wave after wave of enemies being thrown at you. The boss fights are incredibly hard, and each one forces you to employ new tactics. The



most unforgiving part about the whole thing was that you only needed to get hit once to die and you only had a total three lives. Of course, inputting the Konami code gave you 30 lives, but for some boss fights, even that wasn't enough unless you knew exactly what you're doing.

SUPER MEAT BOY

Indie darling Super Meat Boy is credited with being one of the games that put the spotlight on indie games. This was an unforgiving twitch platformer; it had none of the frills or features that normally come with 2D side-scrolling platformers, it was all just pure skill combined with extremely tight and responsive controls. You go into this game expecting to die, a lot. And you'll look damn cool doing it as you keep going splat on every other sharp and pointy surface the game throws at you. Every level will put your skills (and your



sanity) to the test. Despite its difficulty, Super Meat Boy is so addictive you can't decide whether to hold on to the controller for just one more try or throw it at the screen.

MIKE TYSON'S PUNCH-OUT!!

The NES classic, Mike Tyson's Punch-Out!! is one of those games that makes its way onto every one of these 'most difficult games ever' lists. And it does so for the exact same reason, or should we say, exact same level. The final fight against Iron Mike himself. Punch-Out!! has incredibly simple mechanics, when

